STATE SCAN

ODISHA: KEEPING A DATE WITH THE LORD *PG 18*

GUJARAT: GARBA GOES UBER LUXE *PG 20*



ALL EYES ON ALMATTI The 20-year-old dam in north Karnataka, near the Maharashtra border

KPN

KARNATAKA

FOUR-SIDED WAR FOR KRISHNA WATERS

A new conflict looms as Karnataka moves to raise Almatti dam's height. Maharashtra, Telangana, Andhra fume

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

THERE'S NOTHING LIKE WATER TO DIVIDE LAND—or its territory-minded masters. A mere scan of India's hydrological wars would suffice to nail that axiom. The latest river to come to a boil is the Krishna. It's a quadrangular war, since the 1,400-km-long river—the second longest in south India—flows through Maharashtra, Karnataka, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. The contentious piece: the Almatti dam in north Karnataka, which hosts the state's largest reservoir. More than 20 years after it was commissioned, the Karnataka cabinet has cleared a proposal to raise the dam's height in order to capture more of the river's flow.

Part of the Upper Krishna Project, begun in the 1960s, the dam is a central piece of infrastructure meant to help irrigate large arid tracts of northern Karnataka. The current plan, Upper Krishna Project (UKP) Stage III, is ambitious in its scope. It entails acquiring up to 133,867 acres of land; compensation alone, including for submerged areas, would cost an estimated Rs 70,000 crore. It has been in the works since 2010, when the second Krishna Water Disputes Tribunal (KWDT) allowed Karnataka to increase Almatti's height from 519.6 metres to 524.2 metres and utilise up to 907 thousand million cubic (tmc) feet of water